



➤ Agent of Change

❶ Bhargav Dasgupta led ICICI Lombard to listing in 2017, setting industry standards for transparency

❷ He spearheaded a seamless merger with Bharti AXA, propelling ICICI Lombard to become the second-largest general insurer

❸ With a CAGR of 36.5%, ICICI Lombard's PAT grew 78 times under his leadership

❹ He shifted ICICI Lombard's focus from wholesale to retail business to drive growth

DIGITAL LEADER Bhargav Dasgupta, former CEO and MD, ICICI Lombard General Insurance Company

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Dasgupta has accomplished much more than just growing the business through acquisitions. He led a major change at ICICI Lombard, shifting the company's focus from wholesale to the retail business. "Our focus was on doing what was right while balancing growth and profitability. We focussed on building the retail health lines and were more disciplined in the motor segment," says Dasgupta.

To boost growth in the retail health segment, he devised a plan centred around recruiting agency managers who then hired agents to drive business. When it came to claims, the loss ratio in the health segment (including travel and personal accident) for ICICI Lombard increased to 80% in 9MFY24 from 77% in FY23. Despite the rise in claims in the health segment, the combined ratio stayed within the target range at 103.7%.

ICICI Lombard dominates the motor insurance business, with a market share of 12% as of December 2023, which is also the primary component of its product mix at 37%. Considering Own Damage pricing is far more aggressive in motor insurance, Dasgupta says he took a cautious approach to writing businesses in that segment.

Digital was another focus area for Dasgupta. He championed technological innovation for ICICI Lombard's competitiveness and expansion. "We were the first company to go completely in the cloud. It gave us the ability to think about how to be agile, nimble, and future-ready. So, investing in technology and going into new lines of business such as retail health while staying

disciplined helped us grow," says Dasgupta.

He also separated ICICI Lombard's digital division to compete like a start-up. ICICI Lombard's "IL Take-Care" app has achieved 8.5 million downloads as of December 2023 from 4.6 million in March 2023, which is an indication of its growing digital prowess. He also led efforts to expedite claims processing, improve service delivery, and foster a culture of responsiveness and empathy in the organisation, knowing that customer happiness is key to long-term success. Thanks to these measures, ICICI Lombard's complaints as a percentage of policies issued dropped from 0.56% to a mere 0.01% during his tenure.

Throughout his career, Dasgupta has exemplified the qualities of a visionary leader, strategic thinker, and transformational change agent. He was one of the leaders who initiated dialogue with the regulator for dismantling the third-party motor insurance pool due to its rising losses. Talking about his vision for the company, Dasgupta quips, "I don't want to give my vision, as I don't want to cast a shadow on Sanjiv Mantri's [the new CEO] thought process, and it's unfair to him. So, yeah, I just think that the organisation continues to do well. That's all I can say."

As he continues to chart new paths and explore new horizons, Dasgupta's legacy will continue to steer the company ahead. **BT**

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